

THE PATIENT VOICE

THE IMPORTANCE OF THE PATIENT PERSPECTIVE IN THE ABMS COMMUNITY



Presented by:

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DISCLOSURE

RELATIONSHIP TO DISCLOSE

Patient Advisory Board — Beam Therapeutics

Wunmi Bakare serves as a compensated member of the Patient Advisory Board for Beam Therapeutics, a company developing base editing gene therapies with programs relevant to sickle cell disease.

All perspectives shared in this presentation reflect the independent lived experience and advocacy work of the speaker and do not represent the views, positions, or endorsement of Beam Therapeutics.

WHO GUIDES OUR CARE?

*My relationship with healthcare systems has never been passive, because **the system was not designed to protect patients who looked like me.***

However, for most of my life, I did what most patients are asked to do:

I trusted the information



Believing that my physician was knowledgeable, keeping up with the latest clinical evidence and treatment landscape.

I trusted the options



That if other paths existed, I would be told about them.

Patients shouldn't have to become experts

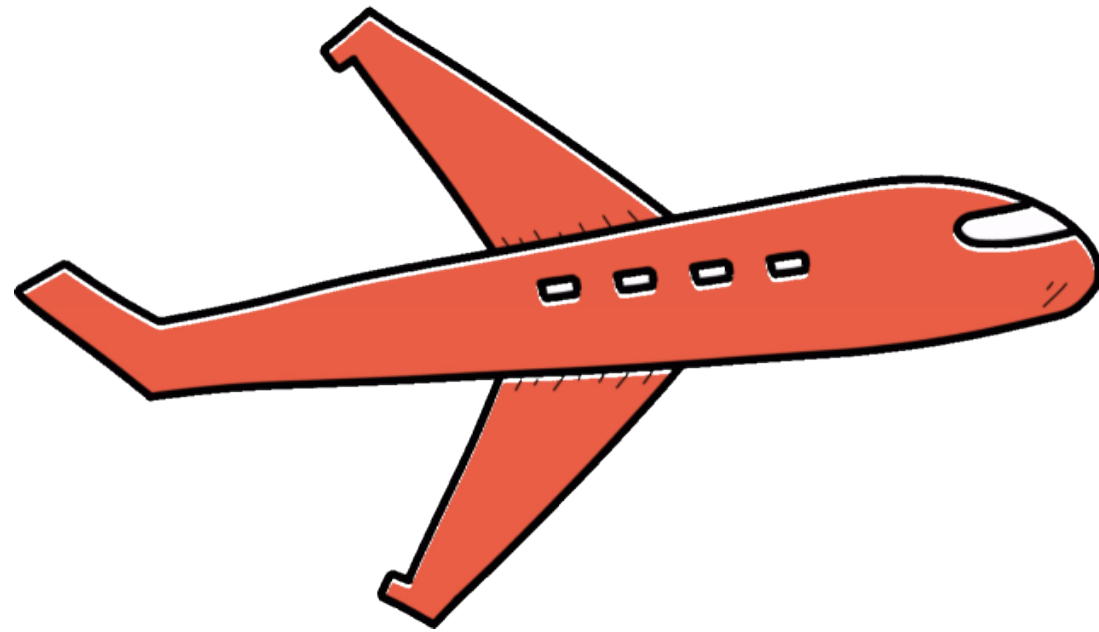


ABMS has spent more than nine decades building a system around a simple but consequential idea: physician competence should be current, verifiable, and worthy of public trust.

A standard only changes a patient's life when that standard reaches the patient.



What happens when there is a gap between the standard we believe exists and the patients actual experience?



CHAPTER ONE

A Two-week Vacation Became Two Years

2015 — Lagos to Seattle

Boarded a flight – packed for a two-week vacation.

01

02

Mid-flight crisis

Intense vaso-occlusive pain crisis on the Amsterdam–Seattle leg.

UW Medical Center

Rushed to the hospital. Diagnosed with Mycobacterium avium complex (MAC) and pneumonia.

03

04

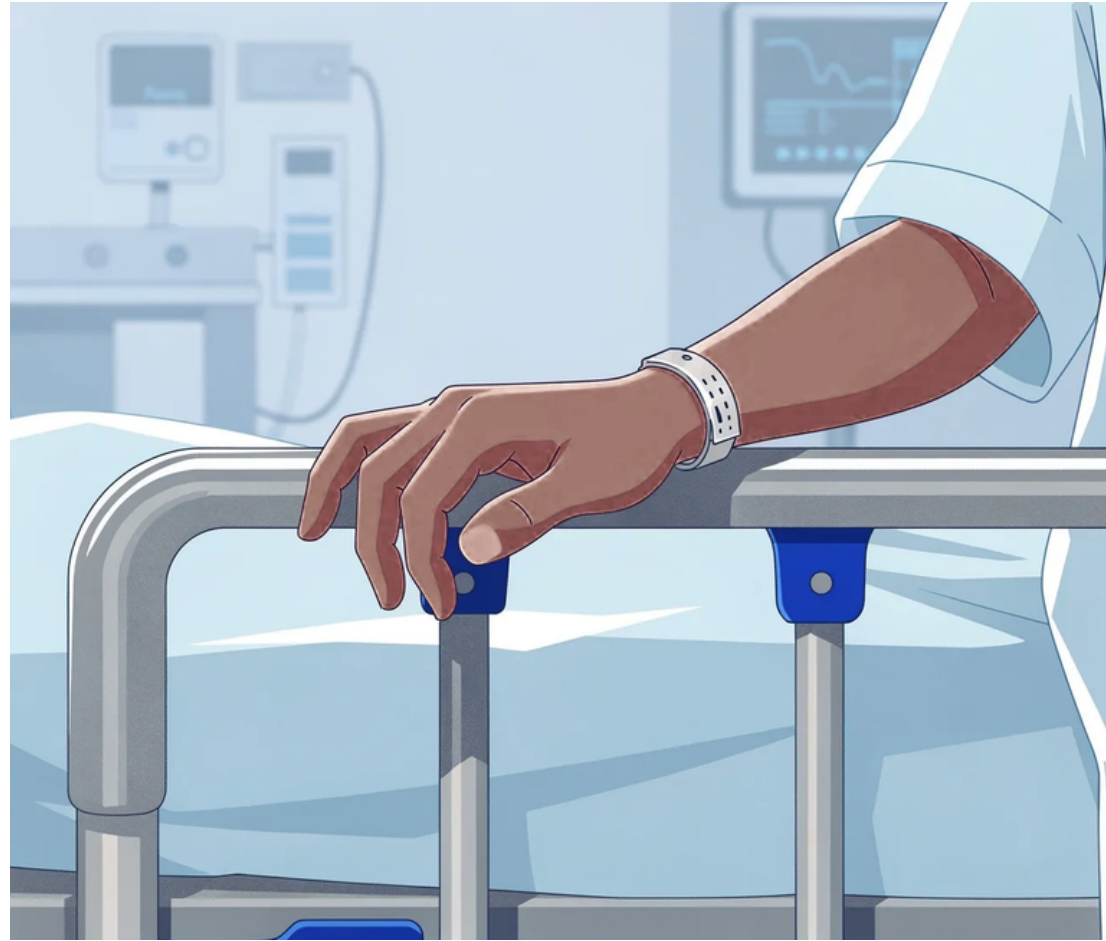
24 months in hospital

Treatments I wasn't prepared for. A two-week vacation became two years of my life.

CHAPTER TWO

When Trust Becomes Vulnerability

Throughout that grueling period, I trusted that my care provider was offering me every appropriate treatment option available.



Multiple Complications

Layered on top of an already complicated disease

The infection spread to major organs

And underneath all of it was still sickle cell disease—the condition that had brought me into that hospital in the first place.

Exhaustion persisted

Not the kind that sleep fixes, but the kind that becomes the new floor of your life.

What the situation revealed

When you don't know what questions to ask, you are completely dependent on whether the person guiding you knows what answers exist.

CHAPTER THREE

1988



Certifying Board: **American Board of Internal Medicine**

Actively Maintaining Certification: **No**

Specialty: **Internal Medicine**
Most Recent Certification:
1985

Subspecialty: **Hematology**
Most Recent Certification:
1988

A license confirmed he could **still practice** — it said nothing about whether his certification was **still current**



New Therapies

Curative therapies for sickle cell were already available to patients at the NIH.



What Happened?

He never told me. Not once. For twenty-four months.



Clinical Advancements

There were advancements in the field of hematology. The possibilities for patients increased. Yet my physician's certification was outdated.



What it Revealed

Who guides your care matters just as much as what care is being offered.

CHOOSING DIFFERENTLY

After my experience I made a decision that has shaped every part of my healthcare journey since: **I would never again assume the full picture was given to me.**

Moving forward...

- **Ask, Research, Seek**

I began asking more questions, seeking second opinions, and paying closer attention to whether the physicians guiding my care were keeping up with advancements in their respective fields

- **Certification as Safety**

Partnering with board-certified physicians became part of how I think about safety, trust, and informed decision-making.

The Distinction Matters...

- **Transplant Experience**

A board-certified physician at the NIH led my transplant team. Restored my faith in healthcare — **my care was grounded in evidence.**

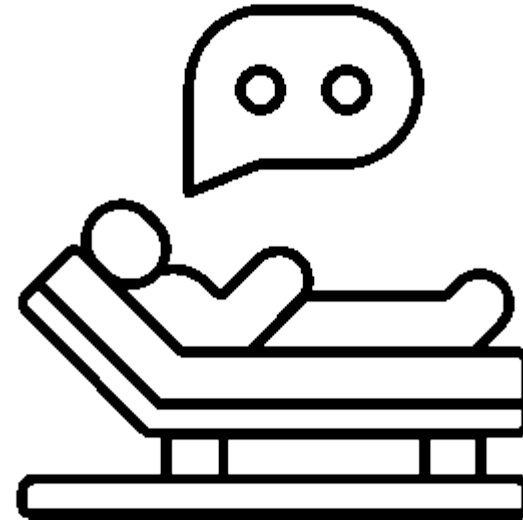
- **A Choice Exists**

As both a patient and an advocate, knowing that physician standards are shaped and upheld by independent organizations like ABMS has strengthened my confidence in the healthcare system.

WHAT CERTIFICATION MEANS TO PATIENTS

SAFETY

A physician whose board certification is current is less likely to miss a treatment option that could change my health outcome.



TRUST

I can't evaluate every clinical decision so certification is a trust signal that I can rely on when I can't independently evaluate my own clinician.

CHOICE

I can't choose what I don't know. Informed consent is not meaningful if as the patient I'm never told that another option exists.

FROM PATIENT TO ADVOCATE

I made a conscious decision: I would not let what happened to me remain a private lesson...

01

Education

I co-founded Sickle Cell Prodigy to ensure other patients and families exploring curative therapies for sickle cell don't have to learn the hard way.

02

Empowerment

I serve on the ABMS Patient and Family Advocacy Council because the same principle that changed my life applies to every patient in the rare disease community: **who guides your care matters just as much as what care is offered.**

03

Inform Policy

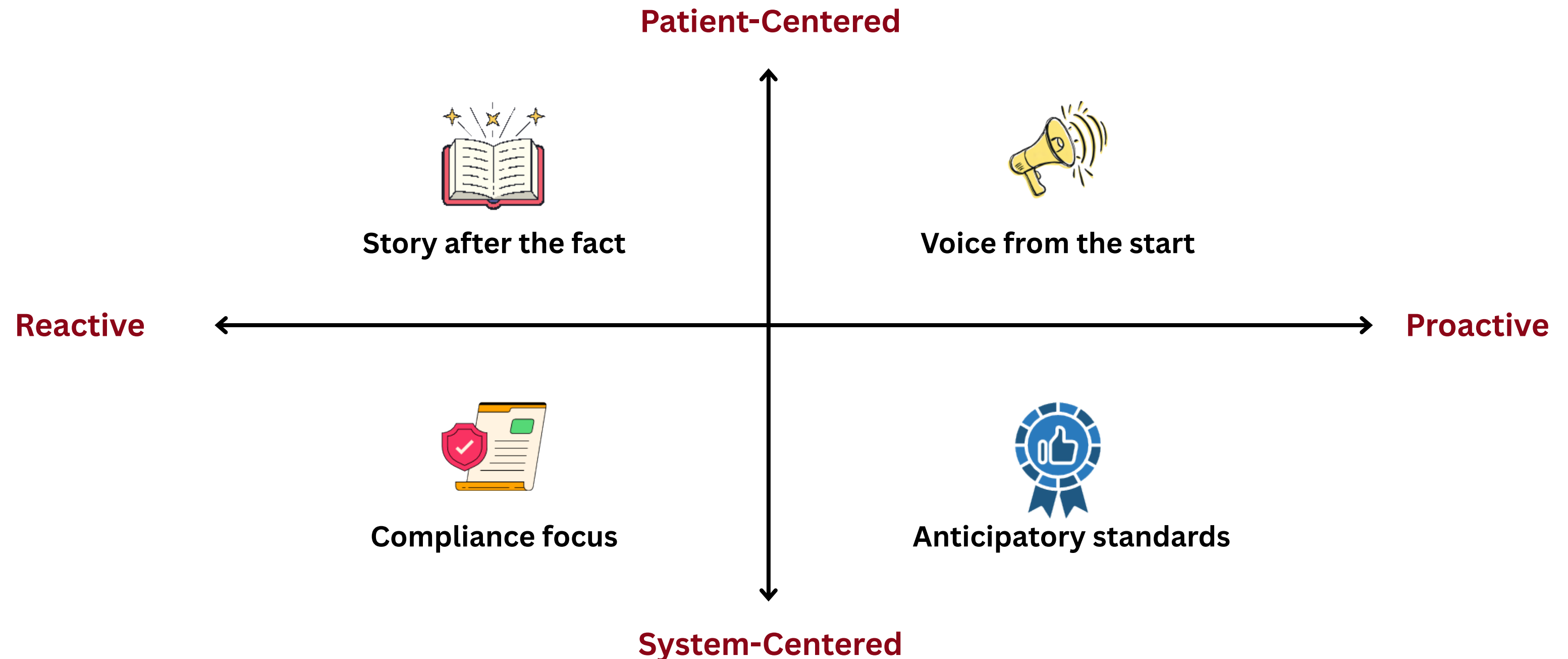
Help inform policymakers about why board certification matters, with one pressing question at the heart of it all: ***How do we ensure that the people for whom these standards exist actually experience their value?***



That is where the patient voice becomes essential. Not as a story we hear after the work is done — but as a voice that helps shape the work from the beginning.

THE PATIENT VOICE MUST SHAPE THE WORK

How do we make sure the people **for whom** these standards exist actually **experience their value**?



WHAT THE ABMS COMMUNITY CAN DO

The next evolution of healthcare standards is co-production



Certification

Include patients and families in **shaping what meaningful competency looks like**—not simply asking us to react after the framework has already been built.

Communication

Help patients understand what certification means.
Empowering patients & families to ask the right questions like ***“Is my physician board certified?”*** or ***“What does that certification mean?”***

Tools like **CertificationMatters.org** exist to answer these type of questions.

Representation + Roles

Build the patient perspective into every phase of the work and keep creating structured seats — like the Patient and Family Advocacy Council — where lived experience has real influence.

THE CHALLENGE

Take the ABMS philosophy one step further

Let the patient perspective evolve with the standards.

THANK YOU



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